

Figure 1.5 *Chihil Dukhtaran* minar*, historical inscription panel. © Photograph Alka Patel 2011.*

this architectural culture expanded eastward with the Saljuqs' imperial ambitions.

The expansion of Saljuq imperialism from the principal cities of Rayy and Isfahan predictably followed well-trodden routes of commerce, communication, and pilgrimage (map, p. xv). Toward the east, the magnificently arresting elite accommodation known as Robat Sharaf (Figure 1.10) attested not only to this eastward expansion, but to several other factors besides: it was an important indication of the continued mobility of Saljuq rule (cf. below) well into the twelfth century, and of the typological variety encompassed within the prevalent architectural culture. Located on the principal route connecting Marv and Nishapur, Robat Sharaf formed a waystation for Saljuq officials and probably also the sultan and his immediate entourage. Based on its epigraphic program, André Godard (1948) proposed that the Robat was initially constructed *c.* AH 508/1114–1115 CE, perhaps even by Sharaf al-Din Abu Tahir ibn Sa'd al-Din ibn 'Ali al-Qummi, who was governor of Marv and eventually Sultan Sanjar's (r. AH 511–552/1118–1157 CE) *vazir*. Other surviving epigraphic remains indicated extensive renovations in AH 549/1154–1155 CE, possibly in the wake of the destructive Oghüz rebellions against Saljuq authority, which resulted in Sanjar's capture and humiliating imprisonment between AH 548 and 551/1153 and 1156 CE.[42] The Robat's brick construction, courtyard–*ivan* configuration (Figure 1.11), and the decorative repertory of extensive epigraphy and floral–geometric motifs (Figures 1.12 and 1.13) altogether provide an exemplar of non-religious building within the so-called Saljuq-patronized